

Introduction

Court Statistics Report

The *Court Statistics Report* is published annually by the Judicial Council of California and is designed to fulfill the provisions of article VI, section 6 of the California Constitution, which requires the Judicial Council to survey the condition and business of the California courts. The *Court Statistics Report* combines 10-year statewide summaries of superior court filings and dispositions with similar workload indicators for the California Supreme Court and Courts of Appeal. The 2026 *Court Statistics Report* also provides more detailed information on filings and dispositions in the individual superior courts for the most recent fiscal year for which data are available, 2024–25.

The California Court System

California's court system serves a population of more than 39 million people—about 12 percent of the total U.S. population—and processed over 5.3 million cases in fiscal year (FY) 2024–25. The judicial branch budget for the 2024–25 fiscal year of \$5 billion (excluding infrastructure) represents about 1.7 percent of the California state budget and makes possible the case-processing activity detailed below while also providing the basis of support for approximately 1,900 authorized judicial positions and over 18,000 judicial branch employees statewide.

The vast majority of cases in the California courts begin in the superior (or trial) courts, one of which resides in each of the state's 58 counties. With more than 450 court buildings throughout the state, these courts hear both civil and criminal cases as well as family, probate, mental health, and juvenile cases. More than 2,000 judicial position equivalents statewide address the full range of cases heard each year by the superior courts. The superior courts report summaries of incoming and outgoing caseload to the Judicial Council, and the *Court Statistics Report* presents those figures here in aggregate form.

The next level of court authority within the state's judicial branch resides with the Courts of Appeal. Most of the cases that come before the Courts of Appeal involve the review of a superior court decision that is being contested by a party to the case. The Legislature has divided the state geographically into six appellate districts, each containing a Court of Appeal. One hundred and six appellate justices preside in nine locations in the state to hear matters brought for review. The Judicial Council generates annual statistics based on Court of Appeal cases, which are summarized in the tables that follow.

The Supreme Court sits at the apex of the state's judicial system and has discretion to review decisions of the Courts of Appeal in order to settle important questions of law and resolve conflicts among the Courts of Appeal. Although the Supreme Court generally has considerable discretion in determining which cases to grant review, it must review the appeal in any case in which a trial court has imposed the death penalty. The Judicial Council generates annual summary information on Supreme Court cases for the *Court Statistics Report*.

Caseload Data and Court Workload

The *Court Statistics Report* contains essential information about the annual caseload of the California judicial branch, with a particular emphasis on the number and types of cases that are filed and disposed of in the courts. This information is submitted to the California Legislature and used in numerous judicial branch reports. As with any published data, the numbers in this report represent a snapshot of the most complete and reliable information available at the time of compilation. Statewide trends in filings and dispositions may be influenced by a number of factors. For example, changes in the number of filings and dispositions may reflect the shifting needs or behavior of residents of a court's service area as well as new policy emphases in the work